

Squish

A stompbox compressor with two characters - a squishy, gritty sustainer and a clean studio compressor - and a big BLEND knob for parallel compression.



Overview

Squish is a pedal compressor with two modes, designed from scratch in the spirit of the classic orange and red guitar sustainer pedals and the modern boutique studio-style pedal compressors. Both modes share the same four controls - SENS, SUSTAIN, ATTACK and RELEASE - and the mode sets the character behind them. The pedal turns orange-red for VINTAGE and steel blue for STUDIO.

VINTAGE is the sustainer: strong ratios, an aggressive squish and a release that stretches out on long, heavy compression, so it holds notes without pumping. Hit it hard and it adds a little lopsided grit, while quiet playing stays clean. STUDIO is a clean, transparent compressor with gentler ratios and a steadier release.

BLEND, the big knob, mixes the dry signal back under the compressed one, so you can keep your pick attack while the notes sustain. Make-up gain is automatic, and there is no latency, so it is safe for live guitar monitoring.

Reach for it for

- Country and funk guitar with that squashed, clucky attack
- Long, singing lead sustain
- Even, punchy bass
- Parallel compression that keeps the transients
- Smoothing strummed acoustic guitar
- Gentle glue on a vocal

Controls

The header

PRESETS, ◀ ▶ and the display	PRESETS (or a click on the display) opens the list of factory presets; ◀ and ▶ step through them, and the display shows the one in use. A new instance opens on Init.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window. A new instance opens in Large.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Mode

VINTAGE / STUDIO	The character (VINTAGE by default). The name and description printed on the pedal follow it. VINTAGE: ratios from about 2:1 to 20:1, a firm knee, a release that stretches on heavy compression, and grit when hit hard. STUDIO: ratios from about 1.5:1 to 8:1, a softer knee, a release that lengthens only a touch, and no grit. Switching is smooth.
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The compressor

The same four controls in both modes.

SENS	How early it grabs, 0 to 100% (50% by default). It sets the threshold from about -10 dBFS (0%) down to -40 dBFS (100%); the knob shows both. In VINTAGE it also sets how hard the input drives the grit.
SUSTAIN	How much it squashes, 0 to 100% (50% by default). It sets the ratio - about 2:1 to 20:1 in VINTAGE, 1.5:1 to 8:1 in STUDIO - and the knee tightens as it goes up. The knob shows the ratio.
ATTACK	How fast it clamps down, 0.5 - 50 ms (3 ms by default). Slower settings let more of the pick attack through before it squashes.
RELEASE	How fast it lets go, 30 - 1500 ms (140 ms by default). In VINTAGE it stretches up to three times longer on long, heavy compression; in STUDIO only a little.

Gain reduction

Meter	A 12-segment ladder of the gain reduction, 1 to 24 dB: amber up to 8 dB, red beyond.
dB GR readout	The gain reduction in dB.
OTA GRIT / CLEAN VCA	In VINTAGE (OTA GRIT) the lamp glows as the input drives the compressor into grit. In STUDIO it reads CLEAN VCA and stays dark.

TONE and LEVEL

TONE	A tilt at 3 kHz, -100 to +100% (FLAT by default): left darkens (DARK), right adds sparkle (SPARK), up to 9 dB either way. It comes after BLEND, so it shapes the whole sound.
LEVEL	Output level, -24 to +12 dB (0 dB by default). Make-up gain is already automatic (about 70% of the reduction at a typical level), so use this to match the bypassed loudness.

IN / OUT

TRIM	Input level before anything else, -24 to +12 dB. Raising it works like raising SENS, but also drives the grit harder.
GUARD	Click the TRIM knob (without turning it) to switch GUARD on or off; the small light at the knob's upper right shows it is on and glows brighter while it works. On by default. Gently eases very hot sources down towards about -18 dBFS average and catches fast peaks above -6 dBFS. It never boosts quiet sources.
DRIFT	0 to 100% (15% by default). See Drift below.

BLEND

BLEND	The big knob: dry / compressed balance, 0 to 100% wet (100% by default). Lower settings bring the uncompressed signal back underneath - parallel compression - so the transients return while the sustain stays. The two stay perfectly in phase, even with the grit.
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In REAPER's parameter list only

On / bypass	Bypass / On (On by default). Bypass crossfades over 10 ms to the raw input, before TRIM; the output stage stays in. There is no key for it on the panel; use REAPER's own bypass, or automate this parameter.
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Drift

DRIFT gives the pedal an uneven supply: the threshold wanders very slightly (up to about 1.5 dB either way at 100%), and so does the bias that sets how lopsided the grit is. At 0% it stays exactly where you set it.

Knobs: drag up or down (Shift for fine moves); double-click to reset a knob to its default. The mouse wheel works too.

Presets

Presets set the mode, the four compressor controls, BLEND, TONE, LEVEL and DRIFT, and switch the plug-in on (out of bypass). TRIM, GUARD and the output stage are left as they are.

Init	VINTAGE with every control at its default: a medium squish at 100% wet.
Country Chicken Pickin'	VINTAGE, quite heavy, a little dry blended in and a bright tone, for clucky, snappy picking.
Funk Squish	VINTAGE, very heavy and fully wet with a touch of sparkle, LEVEL down 1 dB.
Clean Sustain	STUDIO, moderate, with a slower attack and a long 420 ms release; 80% wet.
Parallel Punch	STUDIO, hard and fast, blended 50 / 50 with the dry signal: punchy parallel compression.
Bass Even-Out	STUDIO, moderate, with a slow 15 ms attack, a 300 ms release and a slightly darker tone, for bass.
Acoustic Strum	STUDIO, light, with a 20 ms attack to keep the strum and a brighter tone; 70% wet.
Lead Sustain	VINTAGE, very sensitive and very heavy, for long, singing notes.
Vocal Glue	STUDIO, gentle, with a 350 ms release and a touch of air: light levelling for a vocal.
Slide Sustain	VINTAGE, heavy with a slightly darker tone and a little more drift, 75% wet.

Tips

- Set SENS first, until the meter shows a few dB of reduction on your normal playing, then shape it with SUSTAIN.
- For more pick attack, lengthen ATTACK or lower BLEND. BLEND keeps the attack natural; ATTACK makes it snappier.

- Watch the OTA GRIT lamp in VINTAGE: if you want it clean, lower SENS or TRIM until the lamp barely glows.
- Compression brings up noise as well as sustain. A little DARK on TONE helps with a noisy guitar.
- Compare with REAPER's bypass and set LEVEL so the loudness matches before you judge it.

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